KINGKILLER CHRONICLE TEXT ADVENTURE

Project Planning Document — v1.1

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0. PROJECT MODE AND RELEASE BOUNDARY

This project begins as a **private or tightly limited prototype**. Its first purpose is to prove that a canon-faithful, simulation-first Kingkiller Chronicle text adventure can feel real, consistent, and emotionally right. It is **not** assumed to be a commercial product.

Before any major build work begins, the project must make an explicit release decision:

- **Mode A:** Private prototype only
- **Mode B:** Private invited playtest
- **Mode C:** Public non-commercial fan demo
- **Mode D:** Public/commercial release, only if rights and licensing are properly resolved

This decision matters because it affects tooling, content storage, text reuse policy, distribution, and legal risk.

Default assumption for v1.1: Mode A or B.

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1. PROJECT VISION

What kind of game is this?

This is a **simulation-first, narrative-rich, canon-faithful interactive fiction game** set in the world of Patrick Rothfuss's Kingkiller Chronicle. It is not a combat-centric RPG, not a generic parser fantasy game, and not a choose-your-own-adventure with Kingkiller flavour pasted on top. The point is not "winning." The point is inhabiting the world truthfully.

The game should make ordinary things matter:

- counting money before buying supper
- deciding whether to risk embarrassment in conversation
- crossing to Imre because it matters socially, not just mechanically
- being cold, tired, hungry, late, watched, or quietly ashamed
- feeling that names, music, reputation, and mystery have weight

What does “faithful to Rothfuss” mean in practice?

Faithful means:

- **Tonal faithfulness:** clear, careful, grounded prose with occasional beauty earned through real detail
- **Material faithfulness:** money, rooms, food, tools, distance, weather, and institutional rules all matter
- **Mystery faithfulness:** the great unknowns remain unknown
- **Character faithfulness:** canon characters behave like themselves, not like game dispensers
- **Timeline faithfulness:** what is true depends on where and when the player is

What makes this unlike a generic fantasy text RPG?

Five things define the experience:

1. Social consequences matter more than physical damage.
2. Magic is discipline, cost, and danger, not a power bar.
3. The world does not revolve around the player.
4. Slow play, observation, and restraint are valid play.
5. Uncertainty is a feature, not a flaw.

What this project is not trying to do

This project does **not** aim to simulate the entire Four Corners at once. It aims to create a **dense, truthful slice** of lived reality within canon. Depth outranks breadth. A few richly modelled places are better than a wide, thin map.

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2. DESIGN PILLARS

1. **Canon First**
   Published text outranks design convenience.

2. **Mystery Preserved**
   The game never cheaply resolves the series’ major unknowns.

3. **Social and Material Realism**
   Reputation, class, money, hunger, access, debt, and favours shape play.

4. **Geographic Coherence**
   Places feel connected, navigable, and physically plausible.

5. **Character Authenticity**
   Canon characters remain distinct, limited, and human.

6. **Magic as Discipline**
   Sympathy and naming remain costly, uncertain, and rare.

7. **Timeline Precision**
   Truth depends on era. Knowledge cannot bleed across time.

8. **Consequences That Accumulate**
   Choices persist.

9. **Slow Play Rewarded**
   Listening, noticing, waiting, and restraint matter.

10. **Original but Tonally Compatible Prose**
    Never copy Rothfuss; feel compatible with him.

11. **Engine Owns Truth**
    The structured game systems, not the LLM alone, own canon flags, state, access, and outcomes.

12. **Small Enough to Finish**
    Each phase must end in something playable.

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3. SCOPE DEFINITION

Must Have

- One fully playable era
- One fully playable protagonist
- A dense, coherent cluster of locations
- Persistent world state
- Conversation system with social consequences
- Money and material pressure
- Reputation tracking
- Basic sympathy system with cost and failure
- Canon citation workflow
- Tone and canon review process

Should Have

- One performance/music moment
- One canon-fixed event handled carefully
- A small rumour/clue system
- Time-of-day variation
- Weather presence

- Repeat-visit description variation
- A small academic-pressure loop

Could Have Later

- Additional eras
- Additional protagonists
- Underthing expansion
- Auri content
- Denna as a deeper recurring system
- Tarbean
- Waystone frame mode
- Sygaldry expansion
- Travel beyond the University/Imre slice

Deferred Unless Proven Safe

- Chandrian as playable characters
- Felurian-heavy content
- Auri-first gameplay
- Ademre as a major early target
- full frame-story implementation
- multi-protagonist play in early phases

Should Not Have

- central combat loop
- spell lists
- levelling systems exposed to the player
- procedural worldbuilding that invents lore
- quest markers
- generic filler NPCs as the main content
- fan theory content presented as truth
- any resolution of unresolved series mysteries

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4. CANON AND LORE STRATEGY

Sources of truth

1. **The Name of the Wind**
2. **The Wise Man's Fear**
3. **The Slow Regard of Silent Things**
4. Carefully limited direct author statements, marked as secondary
5. Nothing else as authority

The existing plan already sets this hierarchy well, and that should remain unchanged.

Canon confidence tiers

Every lore element must be tagged:

- **Tier 1:** direct canon statement
- **Tier 2:** strong canonical implication
- **Tier 3:** cautious inference
- **Unresolved:** intentionally unknown

Canon Red List

The game may **never** assert the following as settled fact unless directly supported by published canon:

- Denna's patron identity
- final Amyr truth
- final Chandrian truth
- unpublished Book 3 outcomes
- hidden Names not text-supported
- final explanation of the Doors of Stone

Provenance rule

Every content element must record:

- source book
- chapter reference if possible
- claim summary
- confidence tier
- reviewer status

Contradiction Register

If two passages or implications are in tension, log the contradiction rather than smoothing it over.

Fanon protection

Wikis may only be used as finding aids. Every usable fact must be checked against the books before inclusion. The plan already warns against fanon contamination; v1.1 makes that a formal workflow rule.

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5. WORLD MODEL

Production hierarchy

World → Region → Settlement → Cluster → Space → Object

Why “cluster” matters

The project should be built in **clusters**, not room-by-room in isolation. A cluster is a socially and physically coherent set of spaces that function together.

Examples:

- Anker’s cluster
- Archives cluster
- Fishery cluster
- Eolian cluster

Each space must define

- name
- era availability
- access rules
- adjacent spaces
- traversal time
- operating hours
- ambient sound
- smell profile
- crowd pattern by daypart
- weather effects
- repeat-visit variants
- social risk
- canon tier
- source reference

Physical coherence rules

- Movement takes time
- Restricted places remain restricted unless plausibly opened
- Distance affects scheduling
- University and Imre should feel close but not instant
- Travel outside the MVP cluster is initially off-screen or unavailable, not weakly simulated

MVP world slice

The first slice is **early University + bridge to Imre + limited Eolian access**.

Initial target spaces:

- Kvothe's lodging
- Anker's common room
- Anker's upper corridor / private threshold
- Mains exterior/interior
- one University courtyard or approach
- Archives entrance / public-access threshold
- Fishery outer workspace
- bridge to Imre
- one Imre street
- Eolian floor
- Eolian audience/stage threshold
- one master-facing academic space

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6. CHARACTER MODEL

MVP protagonist

Kvothe only

This is the single most important scope cut in v1.1. Other protagonists are deferred until the first slice is genuinely working.

Major NPC template

Every major NPC requires:

- identity
- era presence
- speech style notes
- daily routine
- social status
- core motives
- key fears
- known capabilities
- known limitations
- public knowledge
- private knowledge
- unknown-in-canon boundaries
- relationship stance toward player
- taboo topics
- conversation exit conditions
- what they notice first
- what makes their tone change

MVP fully modelled NPCs

- Simmon
- Wilem
- Kilvin

MVP partially modelled NPCs

- Anker
- one cameo-pressure NPC: either Ambrose or Denna, but not both deeply

Bespoke rule packs needed later

These characters are too delicate for generic treatment and should not be implemented deeply until later:

- Denna
- Elodin
- Auri
- Bast
- Felurian
- Chandrian figures

The current plan rightly stresses that Elodin, Denna, Auri, Kote, Bast, Fela, and Mola cannot be flattened. v1.1 keeps that, but delays the hardest ones until the engine proves itself.

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7. TIMELINE MODEL

Long-term era structure

- Troupe era
- Tarbean era
- University era
- later travel eras
- frame era

v1.1 implementation rule

Only **one era** is playable in MVP:

- **University era, early term**

Knowledge-state model

Each era must distinguish between:

- what is objectively true
- what the public believes

- what the protagonist knows
- what specific NPCs know
- what is rumour
- what is unresolved

This is crucial in a series built on layered stories, partial truths, and mythic uncertainty. That structure is already implicit in the v1.0 document and should now become explicit in system design.

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8. CORE GAMEPLAY SYSTEMS

8.1 Time model

The game uses a **hybrid time model**:

- local movement/actions consume small time units
- some scenes consume fixed blocks
- travel between clusters consumes meaningful time
- the player always knows rough time of day

MVP time buckets:

- morning
- midday
- afternoon
- evening
- night

8.2 Movement and exploration

- spaces connected by clear exits
- traversal has time cost
- access may depend on hour, rank, relationship, or circumstance
- repeat visits vary by time, weather, world state, and player state

8.3 Conversation

Conversation is not a rigid dialogue tree and not uncontrolled freeform chaos either. It should use structured intent.

Each conversational move has:

- **act:** ask, tell, request, flatter, provoke, deflect, lie, remain silent, leave
- **topic:** person, place, event, rumour, favour, object

- **tone:** careful, warm, casual, bold, manipulative, angry, joking
- **knowledge limit:** the player cannot meaningfully discuss what they do not know

NPC response depends on:

- relationship
- current mood
- social setting
- prior memory
- time pressure
- what the NPC knows about the player

8.4 Inventory

Track only meaningful items:

- clothing
- instrument
- sympathy materials
- books/notes
- food or room-related necessities
- important tokens or debts

No fussy loot system.

8.5 Money and expenses

Use canonical denominations and confirmed prices where available. The v1.0 plan already emphasises the importance of money realism; v1.1 keeps that central.

Track:

- current money
- food costs
- lodging costs
- materials
- academic expenses
- debt

8.6 Reputation

Reputation should be hidden numerically but surfaced descriptively.

Axes:

- student social standing
- academic standing

- trust with specific NPCs
- being watched / mistrusted / barred
- artistic/performance standing if relevant

8.7 Academic pressure

MVP academic systems:

- class attendance matters
- missing obligations matters
- being late matters
- impressions of seriousness matter
- rank progression is present as background pressure, not a fully complete ladder yet

8.8 Music and performance

MVP includes one meaningful music/performance moment. It should affect:

- income opportunity
- nerves/emotional state
- reputation
- social access

8.9 Sympathy

The engine, not the LLM alone, adjudicates:

- whether the binding is plausible
- whether materials are present
- thermodynamic cost
- current body condition
- failure risk

The LLM narrates the result, but the system owns legality and cost.

8.10 Naming

Naming is **not** a normal player-facing system in MVP. It remains:

- rare
- event-like
- heavily gated
- mostly off-system in early development

8.11 Hunger, fatigue, lodging, weather

These are always present but lightly modelled in MVP. They should change what the player can plausibly do, how sharp they feel, and how the world feels.

8.12 Rumours and partial information

The game tracks:

- what was heard
- from whom
- when
- how reliable it seems
- whether it conflicts with other rumours

No “mystery solved” meter for unresolved canon mysteries.

8.13 World state

World state stores:

- obligations missed or met
- who knows what about the player
- location access changes
- current rumours
- active tensions
- NPC schedules and attitudes

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9. NARRATIVE STRUCTURE

Core principle

This is a **sandbox with narrative anchors**, not a branching novel and not a pure life sim.

Three narrative zones

1. Safe Simulation Zone

Ordinary daily life where canon gives room:

- eating
- walking
- attending
- studying
- working
- socialising
- being poor

- making impressions

2. Elastic Canon Zone

Major outcomes are fixed, but texture and approach are open:

- player positioning
- noticed details
- emotional angle
- secondary fallout

3. High-Risk Canon Zone

These scenes require special approval before implementation:

- massacre
- Chandrian aftermath scenes
- major Denna patron implications
- first major naming scenes
- Felurian-heavy content
- intimate Auri content
- frame-story revelation beats

MVP should mostly live in Safe Simulation and Elastic Canon zones.

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10. INFORMATION ARCHITECTURE

Core rule

The data layer must be rich enough that the narration layer does not need to invent structure.

Required entities

Location / Space

- id
- cluster_id
- name
- era availability
- description base
- description variants
- exits
- traversal cost
- access conditions
- hours open

- ambient tags
- smell tags
- crowd pattern
- repeat-visit counter
- canon source
- tier

Character

- id
- name
- aliases
- era availability
- schedule by daypart
- default location
- speech notes
- motive notes
- status
- capabilities
- limitations
- relationship thresholds
- taboo topics
- exit conditions
- secret flags
- canon source
- tier

Item

- id
- name
- significance
- conditions of use
- obtainability
- source

Rumour

- id
- topic
- source
- source reliability
- truth status
- contradiction group
- spread scope
- decay rate

Event

- id
- name
- era
- fixed or dynamic
- trigger condition
- visibility
- blockers
- aftermath states
- player-agency note
- source

Player State

- protagonist
- location
- time of day
- money
- hunger
- fatigue
- sleep debt
- injuries
- inventory
- active obligations
- active lies
- current embarrassment / social flags
- known sympathy operations
- relationship states
- knowledge flags

World State

- active events
- NPC awareness matrix
- schedules
- access changes
- crowd levels
- term week
- weather
- rumour pool
- elapsed time

Canon Citation

- element id
- claim
- source book
- chapter or reference
- confidence tier
- notes

- reviewer signoff

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11. CONTENT PIPELINE

Order of work

Phase prep

Build the **Lore Register** before writing scenes.

Then

1. Define engine schema
2. Build one location cluster
3. Build 3 full NPCs
4. Build 1 complete playable day
5. Run canon audit
6. Run tone audit
7. Expand carefully

Cluster production method

Every cluster gets:

- purpose
- regular users
- tensions
- time-of-day behaviour
- sound/smell/material notes
- access rules
- adjacent spaces
- repeat-visit variation plan
- canon citations

NPC production method

Every NPC gets:

- voice notes
- do-not-write notes
- social stance rules
- topic openness map
- sample interactions
- canon citations

Content budget per cluster

To avoid thin sprawl, each cluster should target:

- 8–15 spaces
- 2–4 major NPCs
- 2–3 ambient recurring presences
- 3 rumours
- 2 repeat-visit variants per key space
- 1 weather variant
- 1 social hazard
- 1 canon anchor event

Review workflow

Every new content cluster must pass:

- canon review
- tone review
- state consistency review
- repeated-visit review
- NPC voice review

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12. MVP RECOMMENDATION

Final MVP

Kvothe-only, early-University vertical slice

Why this is the right MVP

The existing plan already identifies the University as the richest, most grounded starting point because it has the strongest combination of geography, recurring characters, academic structure, money pressure, and daily-life plausibility. That remains the right choice.

Exact MVP scope

- one protagonist: Kvothe
- one era: early University
- one playable span: 1–2 days
- 8–12 spaces
- 3 fully modelled NPCs
- 2 partial NPCs
- one meaningful performance opportunity
- one basic sympathy opportunity
- one canon-fixed event or pressure beat
- money, hunger, fatigue, and social consequence active

MVP success test

The MVP succeeds if a player can:

- wake up as Kvothe
- feel immediate material pressure
- move through a believable slice of the University/Imre environment
- talk to people and feel different consequences depending on tone and standing
- make one bad decision that persists
- make one careful decision that pays off
- attempt one sympathy act with real cost
- end the session feeling that the world is alive, specific, and recognisably Kingkiller

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13. PHASE PLAN

Phase 0 — Rights and Boundaries

Objective: decide project mode and release boundary
Outputs: project mode decision, distribution rules
Risks: building toward an unusable release path
Done when: scope is legally and practically framed

Phase 1 — Canon Bible

Objective: create Lore Register and Canon Red List
Outputs: citation system, contradiction register, confidence tiers
Risks: fanon contamination
Done when: every planned MVP element has a canon trail

Phase 2 — Engine Schema

Objective: define the real data model
Outputs: entities, state model, rule ownership boundaries
Risks: vague architecture leading to hallucinated structure
Done when: locations, characters, rumours, events, and state can all be represented cleanly

Phase 3 — MVP Cluster Build

Objective: build the first University/Imre slice
Outputs: playable spaces, traversal, ambience, time costs
Risks: thin environments
Done when: a player can physically move through the slice with coherent variation

Phase 4 — NPC and Conversation Layer

Objective: implement 3 strong NPCs
Outputs: schedules, dialogue stance rules, relationship shifts
Risks: generic voices
Done when: NPCs feel distinct and respond believably across multiple scenes

Phase 5 — Pressure Systems

Objective: integrate money, fatigue, hunger, obligation, and sympathy cost
Outputs: real tradeoffs
Risks: systems feeling gamey or too light
Done when: the player must make meaningful tradeoffs

Phase 6 — Canon and Tone Audit

Objective: test the whole slice
Outputs: audit report, fixes, transcript review
Risks: unnoticed drift
Done when: the slice survives repeated play without major contradiction

Phase 7 — Controlled Expansion

Objective: expand only after the slice works
Outputs: second cluster or second day
Risks: expansion before stability
Done when: new content preserves quality

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14. RISK ANALYSIS

Risk: scope explosion

Mitigation: Kvothe-only, one era, one slice, one or two days.

Risk: lore contradiction

Mitigation: mandatory citation and contradiction register.

Risk: bland generic fantasy prose

Mitigation: tone checklist and reader review by people who know the books well.

Risk: characters flattening into quest-givers

Mitigation: bespoke voice documents and conversation stance rules.

Risk: magic becoming gamey

Mitigation: engine-enforced sympathy cost, naming removed from normal play.

Risk: “living world” remaining fake

Mitigation: schedules, hours, knowledge propagation, crowd states.

Risk: LLM invents canon

Mitigation: structured engine owns truth; narrator layer only expresses allowed states.

Risk: early implementation of fragile content

Mitigation: keep Chandrian, Denna-heavy mystery, Auri intimacy, Felurian, and frame revelations out of MVP.

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15. TOOLING RECOMMENDATION

Option A — Pure interactive fiction engine

Pros: proven IF structure, strong state control
Cons: may feel rigid for socially nuanced freeform play

Option B — Custom app with structured data only

Pros: maximum control
Cons: heavier lift, slower to iterate, more writing burden

Option C — Hybrid structured engine + LLM narration

Pros: best balance of authored truth and flexible prose
Cons: requires strong guardrails

Recommended approach

Option C: hybrid structured engine plus tightly bounded narration.

Rule of thumb:

- engine owns truth
- data owns canon
- LLM owns expression within boundaries

That matches the project's need for both precision and atmosphere.

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16. VALIDATION AND REVIEW

Canon validation

Every shipped asset must be:

- cited
- tiered
- reviewed
- approved

Tone validation

Every scene should be checked for:

- modern language drift
- generic-fantasy phrasing
- overblown lyricism
- character flattening
- cheap mystery solving

Simulation validation

Ask:

- can a full day pass believably?
- do repeat visits feel different?
- do missed obligations matter?
- does money shape behaviour?
- does social fallout persist?

Regression testing

Keep transcripts of test sessions. Re-run them after major changes to detect:

- canon drift
- state drift
- voice drift

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17. THE TEN MOST IMPORTANT DECISIONS NEXT

1. What is the project mode: private, invited, public non-commercial, or something else?
2. Confirm Kvothe-only MVP?
3. Confirm early-University as the only playable era for now?
4. What exact 8–12 spaces are in the first slice?
5. Which 3 NPCs are fully modelled first?
6. What is the exact time model?
7. What input style is used: parser, guided free text, or hybrid?
8. What system owns rule adjudication?
9. What is the canon citation workflow?
10. What exact condition marks MVP complete?

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18. FINAL RECOMMENDATION

This project should proceed as a **private, canon-disciplined, Kvothe-only University vertical slice** built with a **structured engine and strict lore register**, with the LLM used for bounded narration rather than authority.

Do not try to build the whole dream at once.

Do not try to make every era playable.

Do not start with the hardest characters.

Do not start with the deepest mysteries.

Build one small, true thing first.

If that first slice feels alive, poor, tense, intelligent, specific, and recognisably Kingkiller, then the project has earned the right to grow.